CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

AIRCRAFT MECHANIC (A&P;) IN THE AI ERA

Every repair is signed, logged and legally yours — aviation pays for people it can hold responsible.

★ TL;DR — Around $75K median for licensed aircraft work after 1–2 years of training and the license exams. The catch: there is no shortcut around the license, and sloppy paperwork grounds planes and careers. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

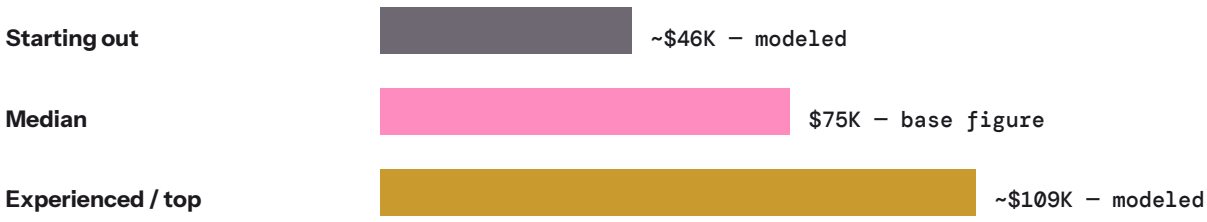
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Why it works: fleets keep aging, flying keeps growing, and only licensed mechanics can return a plane to service.
- Where it bites: night and weekend shifts at hangars and hubs are where the jobs concentrate.
- The AI angle: AI flags maintenance data and writes draft logs — a licensed human still inspects, decides and signs.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Aircraft Mechanic (A&P;) is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A AIRCRAFT MECHANIC (A&P;) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Inspect airframes, engines and systems on fixed schedules
- ✓ Troubleshoot faults from pilot reports and diagnostic data
- ✓ Repair, replace and test components to manual specification
- ✓ Document every action in maintenance records you sign personally

Think: a surgeon whose patient carries two hundred people — and whose signature is part of the medical record.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Predictive maintenance software reads sensor data across whole fleets and flags failures before they happen. Parts tracking, scheduling and log drafting are increasingly automated.	The licensed sign-off is the job. Physical inspection, the judgment call on a borderline part, and legal accountability for the release — none of that transfers to software.

⚠ **The license is the gate: without passing the written, oral and practical exams, you are a helper, not a mechanic — plan the full training runway.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Serious, respected technical work with clear rules ✓ Airlines, cargo, corporate and general aviation options ✓ A license that is recognized everywhere aircraft fly	✗ Shift work — aircraft earn money in the air, not in your hangar ✗ Hub cities dominate; small towns have small fleets ✗ Zero tolerance culture: shortcuts end careers

Good fit? You are meticulous, calm under procedure, and the kind of person who re-checks their own work without being asked.
Bad fit? You cut corners, hate documentation, or want to improvise repairs your own way.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — A&P; SCHOOL	DOOR B — MILITARY / APPRENTICE EXPERIENCE

Approved aviation maintenance programs run about 1–2 years and prepare you for the license exams: written, oral and practical. Graduates walk out examinable, which is exactly what airlines and repair stations hire.	Military aircraft maintenance and long documented apprenticeships can qualify you to sit the same exams. Slower and less structured — you must prove the experience rigorously — but it costs sweat instead of tuition.

Smart move: Add avionics or a specialty while you train. The mechanic who also speaks electronics and composites gets pulled onto the interesting, better-paid work first.
Where you land after: Licensed mechanic, inspector, crew lead, maintenance control, or into corporate aviation where the schedules and pay both improve.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CHOOSE YOUR	TRAIN: AIRFRAME	HANDS-ON PROFICIENCY	PASS THE	FIRST LICENSED	STACK SPECIALTIES

STEP 1 — Choose your license route

FREE · WEEK 1

- Compare local A&P; programs: length, cost, exam pass support
- Confirm the program is approved for license eligibility

STEP 2 — Train: airframe and powerplant

1–2 YEARS

- Work through the full curriculum: structures, systems, engines
- Treat the manuals as the job, not homework — they are the job

STEP 3 — Hands-on proficiency

DURING TRAINING

- Safety wiring, sheet metal, hydraulics, troubleshooting drills
- Build the documentation habit from the first task

STEP 4 — Pass the license exams

EXAM FEES APPLY

- Written exams for general, airframe and powerplant
- Then the oral and practical with an examiner — the mandatory license step

STEP 5 — First licensed job

PAID · AFTER LICENSE

- Airlines, cargo carriers, repair stations and FBOs hire newly licensed mechanics
- Expect shift work; bid better schedules as seniority grows

STEP 6 — Stack specialties YEAR 2+

- Avionics, composites, inspection authorization later
- Specialists and inspectors set the ceiling in this trade

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: list approved A&P; programs near you and what the license exams involve.
- □ Days 1–30: apply and enroll, or start documented apprentice/military route paperwork.
- □ Days 31–60: settle into training — systems, tools and the manual discipline.
- □ Days 61–90: build hands-on proficiency and start exam-style study habits.
- □ Day 90: you are in the pipeline — the license lands at the end of 1–2 years of training, and every employer knows it.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **YOU SIGN IT. IT FLIES.** ★